battle of the Crusaders,' wrote Lady Sale. 'The enemy rushed on and drove our men before them like a flock of sheep with a wolf at their heels. As they captured our gun, our artillerymen fought like heroes; two were killed at the gun; Sergeant Mulhall received three wounds; poor Laing was shot while waving his sword over the gun and cheering the men. It was an anxious sight, and made our hearts beat.'[79]

Shelton, however, managed to keep his one remaining square intact and ordered his bugler to sound the halt. Then he counter-attacked with bayonets, retrieving the gun and in hand-to-hand fighting killing both Mir Masjidi and the military commander of the rebellion, Abdullah Khan Achakzai. 'The news of the Ghazi's death bereaved every Muslim, especially the members of Afghani tribes,' wrote Sultan Mohammad Khan Durrani. 'Had he not lost his life, the Ghazis would have captured the British Cantonment on that day itself.'[80]

For a while the British seemed to have the upper hand. But when the Afghans retreated and the remnants of the two squares reformed, the jezail marksmen resumed their fire, and further ranks of sepoys began to fall where they stood. 'The Brigadier was then urged and entreated to seize the decisive moment to charge the enemy,' wrote George Lawrence, who was looking on with horror from the cantonment walls, 'but from some unexplained cause nothing could induce him to stir from the hill.'[81]

Then a second party of rebel swordsmen assembled in the hidden gully, ready for a final assault. This time all the troops broke rank and fled back to the cantonment, pursued by the Afghan cavalry. 'All order was at an end,' noted George Lawrence.

> I could see from my post our flying troops hotly pursued and mixed up with the enemy, who were slaughtering them from all sides: the scene was so fearful I can never forget it. On came the fugitives, pouring into the cantonment, which we fully expected the Affghans to enter along with them. Fortunately for us, and most unexpectedly, the Affghan cavalry suddenly swept to the right, directed, as we afterwards heard, by Mahommad Osman Khan Barakzai, who was one of the chiefs then in communication with Sir W Macnaghten. But who can depict the horror of that night, and our consternation, for we felt ourselves doomed men? Nothing of course could justify the conduct of our troops; but the total incapacity of Brigadier Shelton, his reckless exposure of his men for hours at the top of a high ridge to a destructive fire, and his stubborn neglect to avail himself of the several opportunities offered to him throughout the day – by the temporary flight of the enemy, to complete their dispersion – go far to extenuate the soldiers, who had lost all confidence in a leader who had proved himself so incapable of command.[82]